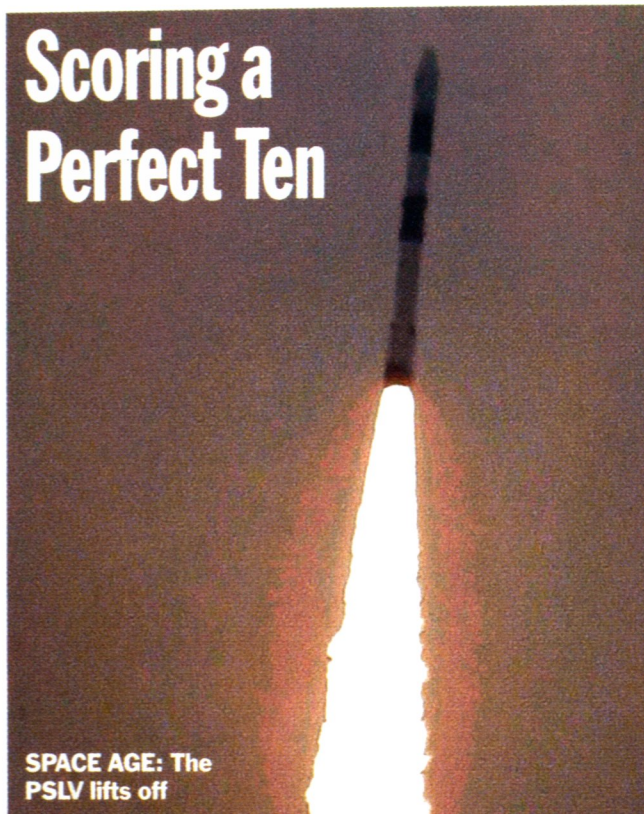


AP PHOTO M. LAKSHMAN

BANGALORE For Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO), precision and timing played out perfectly when its 13th polar satellite launch vehicle (PSLV) fired off 10 satellites into space from the Satish Dhawan Space Centre at Sriharikota on April 28. Putting two Indian and eight foreign satellites into orbit, the launch put India firmly amongst the global leaders of space programmes. "We have set a record. Only Russia had so far tried to launch 13 satellites in a single launch and I am not sure whether that was successful," says ISRO Chairman G. Madhavan Nair.

ISRO's commercial arm, Antrix Corporation, earned about Rs 2.5 crore from the launch of the eight mini-satellites weighing a total 50 kg. It charged \$12,000 (Rs 5 lakh) per kg as against the commercial price of \$8,000 (Rs 8 lakh)



SPACE AGE: The PSLV lifts off

per kg since the eight nano satellites were designed and developed by universities and research bodies in Canada, Denmark, Germany and The Netherlands.

The two indigenous satellites—Cartosat-2A meant for beaming and preparing maps and IMS-1 for remote sensing—accompanying the eight others are designed to

monitor droughts, map floods and general crop management. Cartosat-2A has a life expectancy of five years and will complement Cartosat-2, which is already beaming images since January 2007. The 690-kg satellite was built at a cost of Rs 240 crore.

Since its launch in 1993, the PSLV has carried 10 Indian remote sensing satellites, 14 small satellites for foreign customers including an amateur radio satellite, a meteorological satellite and India's first recoverable capsule. In the past, India has launched satellites from Germany, South Korea, Belgium, Indonesia, Argentina, Italy and Israel. Later this year, the versatile PSLV will take Chandrayaan-1, India's first lunar probe, on the first leg of its voyage to the moon. For India, its space walk seems to have finally taken off at full blast.

by Stephen Davis

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

Lok Sabha polls are nowhere near but there is a clamour in the Congress for the Lucknow seat. The rationale is that with Atal Bihari Vajpayee opting out of electoral politics, the seat would be 'safe'. If only wishes were horses.

VOICES



"I don't say this as prime minister of India. I say this as the proud father of three daughters. I wish for every girl in India what I wish for my daughters."

Manmohan Singh, prime minister

"Initially, the Government blamed the previous NDA rule for its failure. Then they blamed the states. Now they're blaming the global situation for price rise."

L.K. Advani, leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha

"The Communists accuse us of not working according to the Constitution. But they do not talk of wrecking the Constitution anymore. This is the strength of democracy."

Pranab Mukherjee, external affairs minister

"IPL doesn't own India. If tomorrow Sourav Ganguly joins ICL, will the Board bar him from playing for India? The best players should be allowed to play for the country."

Kapil Dev, former India cricket captain

"Till now only cricket was played in the field. However, now things are changing with cheer girls being brought to seduce the crowd."

Bal Thackeray, Shiv Sena supremo

